



SYSTEMATIC THEOLOGY

FOUNDATIONS FOR FAITH AND LIFE



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INTRODUCTION

- **Systematic theology:** any study that answers the question, “What does the whole Bible teach us today” on a given topic.
- **A doctrine:** what the whole Bible teaches us today about a particular topic.
- ST summarizes each doctrine as it should be understood and applied by present-day Christians.
- Study ST so you obey the Great Commission, overcome wrong ideas, make better decisions on new questions, and grow as Christians (Matt. 28:19–20).
- Study ST with prayer, humility, reason, help from others, by collecting and understanding all the relevant passages of Scripture on any topic, and with rejoicing and praise.



PART I: THE WORD OF GOD



WORD OF GOD

The Son of God, direct speech by God (decrees, personal address), God’s speaking through prophets, and God’s Word in written form. (John 1:1).

- The Apocrypha merely human words, not godbreed like scripture.
- Ultimately, we base our confidence in the correctness of our present Canon on the faithfulness of God (Rev. 22:18–19).



CANON OF SCRIPTURE

The list of all the books that belong in the Bible.

- The Bible contains all the words of God. He intended for us to have (Deut. 4:2).
- Scripture primarily reports God’s great acts in redemptive history.
- Primarily, the apostles were given the ability from the Holy Spirit to recall accurately the words and deeds of Jesus and to record and interpret them rightly (John 14:26).
- 39th Paschal Letter of Athanasius (AD 367) and Council of Carthage (AD 397) agreed on our present day Canon.
- The early church recognized but did not bestow divine authority on the books of the Bible it included in the Canon. There’s no need for more words of scripture after the New Testament because there is a finality to the revelation of Christ, of God in Christ (Heb. 1:1–3).
- The Apocrypha merely human words, not godbreed like scripture.
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AUTHORITY OF SCRIPTURE

All the words in Scripture are God’s words in such a way as to disbelieve or disobey any word of Scripture is to disbelieve or disobey God (2 Tim. 3:16–17).

- **Scripture is self-attesting.** All the words in Scripture are God’s words because that this is what the Bible claims for itself, and because we are convinced by the Holy Spirit that the Bible is God’s word as we read it (1 COR 2:13–14). God’s words cannot be “proved” by appeal to any higher authority.
- **Inerrancy.** Scripture is the original manuscript does not affirm anything that is contrary to fact (Psalm 19:7–11).
- The Bible still speaks in ordinary language of everyday speech, including loose or free quotations, and has unusual or uncommon grammatical constructions.





PART I: THE WORD OF GOD

(CONTINUED)



CLARITY OF SCRIPTURE (PERSPICUITY): the Bible is written in such a way that its teachings are able to be understood by all who will read it seeking God's help and being willing to follow it (Deut. 6:6–7).

- Understanding Scripture rightly is more a moral and spiritual than intellectual ability.



NECESSITY OF SCRIPTURE: The Bible is necessary for knowledge of the gospel and maintaining spiritual life and certain knowledge of God's will (Matt. 4:4).

- Knowledge of God and creation gained from Scripture must be used to interpret correctly the creation around us.
- General (or natural) revelation can provide a knowledge that God exists and a knowledge of some of his attributes simply from observation of themselves and the world around them. It can also provide an awareness of sin, but cannot teach the way of salvation (Rom. 10:13–17).
- Special revelation refers to God's words addressed to specific people at specific times.



SUFFICIENCY OF SCRIPTURE: Scripture contains all the words of God he intended his people to have at each stage of redemptive history, and it now contains everything we need God to Tell us for salvation, for trusting him perfectly and for obeying him perfectly (Deuteronomy 29:29). God does not require us to believe anything about Himself or His redemptive work that is not found in Scripture.



PART II: THE DOCTRINE OF GOD

- We can know God exists because all people have an *inner sense of God* (Rom. 1:19–25) and because of the evidence found in Scripture and in nature.
- Sin will cause people to deny their knowledge of God and because of this they are without excuse before him (Rom. 1:18).



TRADITIONAL “PROOFS” FOR GOD’S EXISTENCE



- **Cosmological:** everything has a cause and the cause of such a great universe can only be God.



- **Teleological:** since the universe appears to be designed with a purpose, there must be an intelligent and purposeful God who created it to function this way.



- **Ontological:** God is a being “greater than which nothing can be imagined,” and the characteristic of existence must belong to such a being, since it is greater to exist than not to exist.



- **Moral:** all people have a sense of right and wrong so there must be a God who is the source of this who will someday mete out justice to all people.



- God must enable us to be persuaded or we would never believe in him. We depend on God's active communication to us in Scripture for our true knowledge of him (Matt. 11:27).

